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Sultans, Mughals, and pre-colonial Indian society

Imagine a time traveller standing in Mughal Delhi, amidst the splendor of the emperor Shah Jahan's (r. 1627–58) elegant, riverside city, in the year 1707 (plate 1.1). News had come of the death of Shah Jahan's long-ruling son, Aurangzeb (r. 1658–1707) in the distant Deccan, where he had been engaged in arduously extending his vast empire. The traveller, understandably wondering what the death of a mighty monarch would mean, might first have looked back in time a century, say to the death of Shah, Jahan's grandfather, Akbar (r. 1556–1605). Had he done so, he would have seen the key institutions in place that had made the Mughals, in the intervening century, the most powerful empire the subcontinent had ever known. It was far greater in population, wealth, and power than the contemporaneous Turko-Mongol empires with which the Mughals shared so much: the Persian Safavids and the Ottoman Turks. The Mughal population in 1700 may have been 100 million, five times that of the Ottomans, almost twenty that of the Safavids. Given the trajectory of continuity and growth that had taken place in the seventeenth century, our time traveller at the turn of the eighteenth century might legitimately have imagined a Mughal future to match the glorious past.

But if, Janus-faced, the traveller then looked ahead a century, say to 1803, he would have found not continuity but extraordinary change. He would have seen an empire existing only in name amidst a landscape of competing regional powers. Among these regional states was one which, in 1707 only a minor European trading

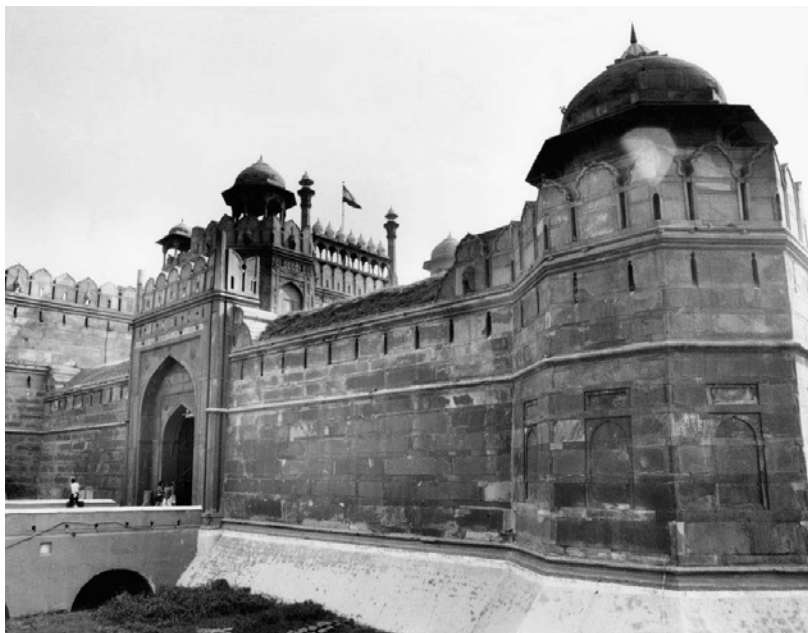


Plate 1.1 Shah Jahan's Red Fort, Delhi, now flying the flag of the republic of India.

body operating from coastal enclaves, was now transformed into a governing body based in the rich, eastern province of Bengal. The Mughal emperor, though still a symbolic overlord, was now confined to the area around Delhi, himself prey to Afghans, the western Deccan-based Marathas, and, in 1803, placed under the control of that very English Company which, as this new century turned, had lately come to a vision of creating an empire itself.

The most familiar ways of understanding the Mughal era in Indian history were forged in a framework created by the British as they themselves devised a national history for their own emerging nation. Central to their image of themselves, as well as to their image of what they came to see as a backward but incipient nation, was what the historian David Arnold has called the Orientalist 'triptych' of Indian history. In this vision, ancient 'Hindus' had once created a great civilization. With the advent of Islamic rulers in the early thirteenth century, Indian culture rigidified, political life gave way to despotism, and the gap between foreign 'Muslim' rulers and a native 'Hindu' populace of necessity made for a fragile

structure. Moral arguments, particularly a focus on what became a caricature of Aurangzeb's 'intolerance', were central in explaining 'decline'. Stage three brought modern British colonial rule with its enlightened leadership, scientific progress, and professed tutelage to independence. This tripartite schema was explicit in much British writing, and it often underlay even anti-colonial Indian nationalist historiography. Even today it has been tenaciously persistent as unrecognized 'common sense' in historical writing; and, as we shall see in [chapter 9](#), this periodization is today treated as fact in Hindu nationalist ideologies.

Today historians of the centuries preceding the British period reject the earlier characterizations of the period of the Muslim dynasties. They also argue, perhaps surprisingly, in relation to the eighteenth century, that it was the culmination of long-term transitions in trade, finance, culture, and society that offered the English the very resources they needed to exercise their own remarkable innovations in finance, organization, and military and naval technology. This chapter introduces the middle frame of the 'triptych', covering roughly 1206 to 1707, when patterns were set that help explain our traveller's view both back in time and ahead.

THE DELHI SULTANATE

The common image of India's past has been profoundly influenced by two interrelated misperceptions: one that the classical texts of the Brahmins described an existing society; and, second, that, because India was 'timeless', the village and caste organization of colonial or even contemporary India was a guide to its historical past. In fact, the periods of the Sultanate and Mughal rule accelerated already existing patterns of change. These centuries saw the expansion of the agricultural frontier, extensive commercial networks, gradual technological change, and development of political and religious institutions. These changes, not some stagnant society, form the prelude to the colonial era. Nor, one might add, did Muslim rulers fit the caricature assigned them. It is, for instance, misleading to speak of them as 'foreign', for, in patterns set by the earliest Sultanates, Muslim and non-Muslim polities and cultures changed in interaction with each other. It is also misleading to speak of this era as the period

of 'Muslim' rule. Such an expression exaggerates the differences between states ruled by Muslims and those ruled by non-Muslims. It also obscures the participation of non-Muslims in the Muslim-led polities. It may further suggest that there were religious practices, like mass conversion, that did not exist.

Successive Turko-Afghan regimes, collectively known as the Delhi Sultanate, dominated political life in the north, with periodic incursions into the south, during the late thirteenth and fourteenth centuries. These Turks and Afghans, like invaders before them stretching back two millennia, originally entered the subcontinent through the mountain passages of the north-west. One immediate corrective to much scholarship is to emphasize how much their kingdom had in common with other Indic polities of the day. Like these other states, including that of the celebrated Rajput Prithviraj Chauhan, the Turks and Afghans sought above all military successes in order to secure access to the agricultural surplus of the countryside. Like them, they possessed a fragmented political authority, with rights to a share of the land revenue of a specific area assigned to their subordinates as a form of compensation. Also like them, the Delhi Sultans offered scope to individual achievement, above all through military prowess. Any periodization predicated simply on the religion of the rulers would miss such fundamental similarities. The Turks and Afghans were invaders, but they behaved in ways that were familiar to their enemies. The 'Turks', as these rulers were conventionally called, were assimilated to such familiar categories as *yavana*, 'Ionian', the term used to describe the Greek invaders who followed Alexander the Great a millennium before, or *mlecca*, 'barbarians', a term for those outside the area of settled Indic civilization whether from distant areas or nearby jungles.

The core military and economic institutions of these dynasties were thus not specifically 'Islamic'. The sultans themselves were not religious leaders. Like non-Muslim rulers, they did not gain their authority through their own holiness or sacred learning but through their military and governing skill. They were expected, however, to patronize those who were holy and learned. The historian Peter Hardy has called the sultans 'pious policemen' collaborating with 'pious lawyers'. Muslim rulers patronized not only the learned legal scholars, or *'ulama*, who had mastered the sacred Arabic texts, but also the moral guides and spiritual intermediaries, the *sufi shaiikhs*.

These two bodies of specialists had emerged as the foci of community life among Muslims from the eleventh century on. Non-Muslim rulers, whether warrior rajas or lesser lords, in similar fashion patronized Brahmans. The Brahmans both cultivated ritual and legal learning as recorded in the sacred Sanskrit texts, and played roles in the temple cults where devotional piety (*bhakti*) flourished in the centuries of Sultanate rule.

For all these institutional similarities between Muslim and non-Muslim states, Muslim dynasties did chart new directions. For over 600 years following the establishment of the first Turkic dynasty in Delhi by the Mamluk or Slave ruler Qutbu'd-din Aibak, in 1206, the language of the Muslim ruling elite was Persian. As participants in a Persian-speaking culture that stretched into central and south-west Asia, these dynasties were a conduit for introducing innovations in ruling institutions, as well as distinctive cultural traditions in law, political theory, and literary and religious styles. They also brought practical innovations in mounted warfare, cropping patterns, and irrigation techniques, like the widespread 'Persian' wheel. They fostered urban growth and road networks that encouraged trade within the region and beyond. Arabic-speaking Muslims had been present much earlier in the subcontinent, establishing a kingdom in Sind in the lower Indus valley in 711 as part of the expansion of the Umayyad dynasty based in Damascus. They were also found by the eighth century as traders along the Malabar coast of the south-west, where they settled, intermarried, and sustained distinctive cultural forms forged from their Arab ties and local setting, and in so doing helped link 'al-Hind' to seaborne trade routes. In the years from roughly 1200 to 1500, the movement of goods and peoples through Indian Ocean ports, as well as overland through the Persian-speaking lands, was such that Janet Abu-Lughod has characterized this period as an 'Islamic world system' of economic and political interaction. In this system, the Indian subcontinent played a significant part. Participation in these ruling and trading networks did not require that individuals be Muslims, but Muslim political expansion facilitated the success of the whole.

Another pattern set early in the Sultanate period was the enduring ethnic and linguistic pluralism of both the ruling elites and those ruled. The rulers comprised not only those of Turkic heritage but also Afghan, Persian, and native-born as well as immigrants from

afar. Of these the best known was the great Moroccan traveller and memoir writer, Ibn Batuta (d. 1368–9), for whom Arabic legal knowledge was a passport to travel and employment. Ibn Batuta served the Tughluq dynasty of the fourteenth century as chief judge of Delhi; and his memoirs are testimony to the cosmopolitan vitality and variety he encountered. His first encounter with the sultan recorded the court's enthusiasm for travellers:

I approached the sultan, who took my hand and shook it, and continuing to hold it addressed me most affably, saying in Persian, 'This is a blessing; your arrival is blessed; be at ease; I shall be compassionate to you and give you such favors that your fellow-countrymen will hear of it and come to join you.' Then he asked me where I came from and I said to him, 'From the land of the Maghrib.' ... Every time he said any encouraging word to me I kissed his hand, until I had kissed it seven times, and after he had given me a robe of honor I withdrew.

The subjects of the dynasties were primarily non-Muslim, designated as *zimmi*, 'protected people', left to their own law and customs. They were, in principle, liable to a capitation tax (*jizya*) but not subject to military conscription. Law, generally, was administered according to the law of the parties or, if they differed, that of the defendant. For most Muslims, that meant Hanafi law shared with central and south-west Asia, while for those of the south, with their Indian Ocean ties to Arabia, law was Maliki. It was accepted here as elsewhere in Muslim polities that administrative law on such matters as taxes would have its own codes apart from the divinely sanctioned *shari'a* norms based on classical Arabic texts. The creativity and vigour of cultural life on all sides was shaped by this pluralism.

For the Sultanate rulers, as for the Mughals who succeeded them, Islamic ambitions focused on extending Muslim power, not on conversion. One clue to the lack of any systematic programme of conversion is that India's Muslim populations were not primarily found in the core areas of Muslim rule. Historians have long asserted that converts flocked to the sufi message of equality to escape the hierarchic discriminations of a Brahman-dominated 'caste' society. There is, however, no correlation between areas of Brahmanical influence and those of substantial conversion to Islam – and the extent of Brahmanical influence in the pre-colonial period, in any case, is increasingly contested. Nor, perhaps surprisingly, did the sufis

themselves ever teach that Islam offered social equality. Indeed, however much they may have preached equality before Allah, Muslims have always lived in hierarchic societies.

In areas undergoing agrarian settlement, sufis did nevertheless play a key role as agents of gradual incorporation into the larger cultural and civilizational structures of the day. They received grants of forested land whose clearing they oversaw, and they served as mediators to both worldly and divine powers. Richard Eaton has shown the importance of this process for the two main areas that were to emerge with largely Muslim populations, western Punjab and eastern Bengal. In other areas Hindu religious specialists performed much the same role. In the Telugu region of south-east India, for example, as Cynthia Talbot has shown, the establishment of new temples was associated with agricultural expansion in the contemporaneous Kakatiya kingdom (1175–1324). A second force driving conversion, for individuals or clusters of artisanal or other families, was, according to Susan Bayly, not a desire to escape hierarchy, but rather a desire to seize a strategic opportunity to move upwards within the existing social hierarchy. Intermarriage also contributed to the growth of the Muslim population, as did the choice of individuals or families to follow charismatic teachers. When the first censuses were taken in the late nineteenth century, the Muslim population of British India was roughly one-quarter of the whole.

Historians now discredit not only accounts of forced mass conversion, but also accounts of systematic destruction of temples and other non-Muslim holy places. As in the case of accounts of conversions, reading the Muslim court histories as matters of fact, rather than as literary convention, has misled many scholars. There was, to be sure, destruction of non-Muslim temples and places of worship under specific circumstances, for example while raiding areas outside one's own territories for plunder. The most famous of such forays, perhaps, are those of Mahmud Ghaznawi (d. 1030) into Sind and Gujarat. Mahmud was drawn to the riches of India to secure booty for his cosmopolitan court at Ghazna (in contemporary Afghanistan), in a manner not unlike the raids of Indic rulers who carried away vanquished idols as symbols of their victory along with their booty. The sultans who established permanent courts in north India also destroyed temples during the initial phase of conquest

to mark their triumph. The complex of the early twelfth-century Quwwatu'l-Islam mosque, adjoining the great minaret of Delhi, the Qutb Minar, was built on the site of destroyed temples and utilized elements of the earlier structures. The use of 'recycled' elements from earlier structures – as true around the Mediterranean, for example, as for India – was sometimes a declaration of power, sometimes simply expedient use of abandoned debris. Firoz Shah Tughluq (r. 1351–88) chose to adorn his fort built in the mid-fourteenth century, for example, with a column from a millennium and a half earlier, whose builder had long been forgotten, as a way perhaps to assert a link to some ill-defined earlier glory (plate 1.2).

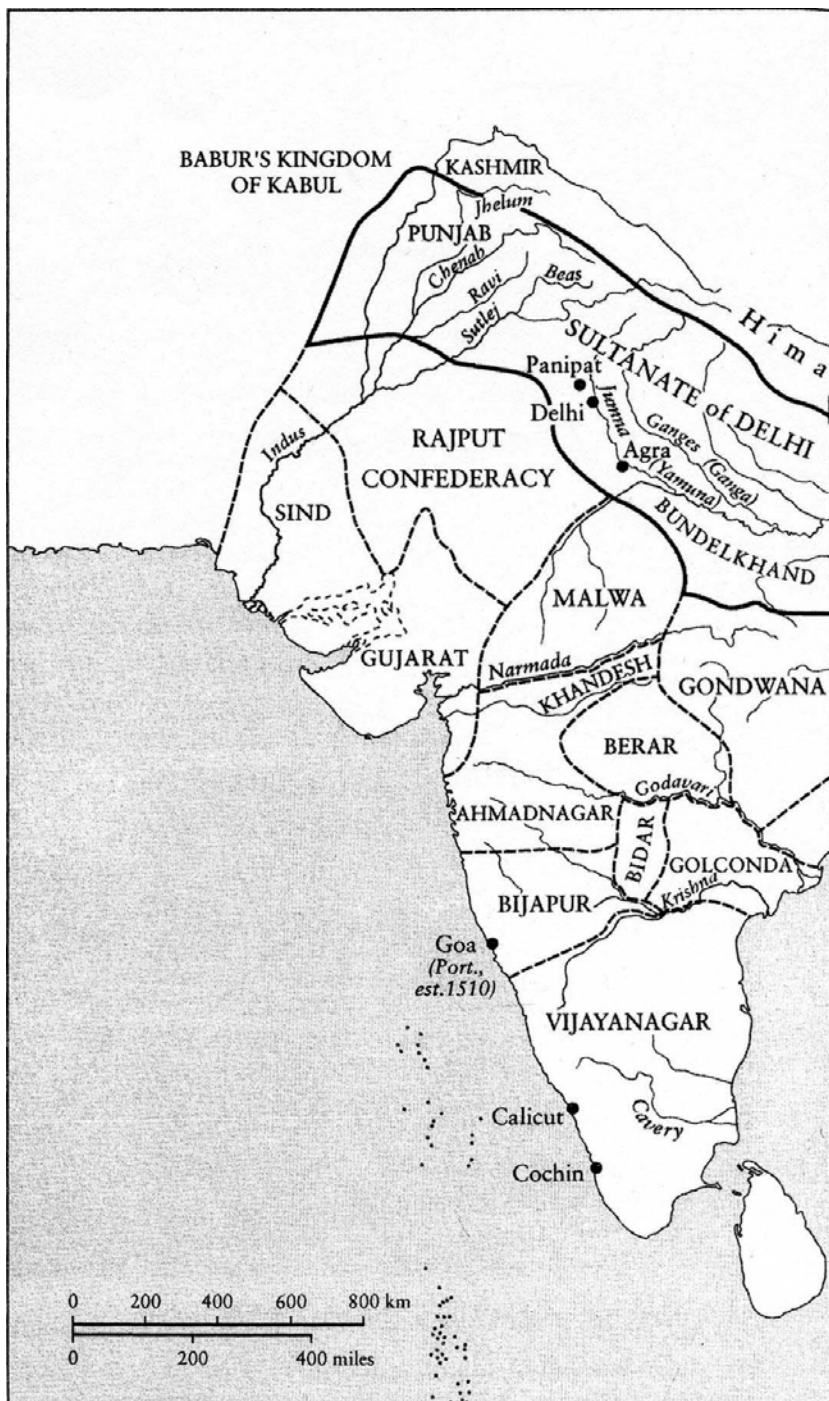
Muslim spiritual and philosophical life in India evolved together with the religious life of non-Muslims. Each was responding to a shared context and, at the same time, interacting with the other's expressions of their respective traditions. No cultural pattern of the Sultanate period was more enduring for the Muslim population than that of sufi devotionism. Indeed, one of the defining characteristics of Islam in the Indic context throughout its long history is the pervasiveness in discourse and institutions of the sufi tradition. Like the 'ulama associated with the courts, the sufi holy men typically adhered to the shari'a, but they also stressed inner realization of the divine presence, the practice of moral and physical disciplines, and the need to submit to the authority of charismatic chains of saintly authority. They served the rulers, yet, to a varying degree, sought to present themselves as distant from the corruption of worldly rule. The founders of the most important sufi lineages, Chishti, Suhrawardi, Qadiri, and Naqshbandi, were central and west Asian in origin, but they flourished in the subcontinent. Sufi teachings were enriched and stimulated by the presence and competition of similar holy men of the Indic bhakti traditions of devotion, spiritual disciplines, and sophisticated monistic philosophies. Bhakti devotion and worship, in turn, flowered as well.

THE EMERGENCE OF REGIONAL KINGDOMS

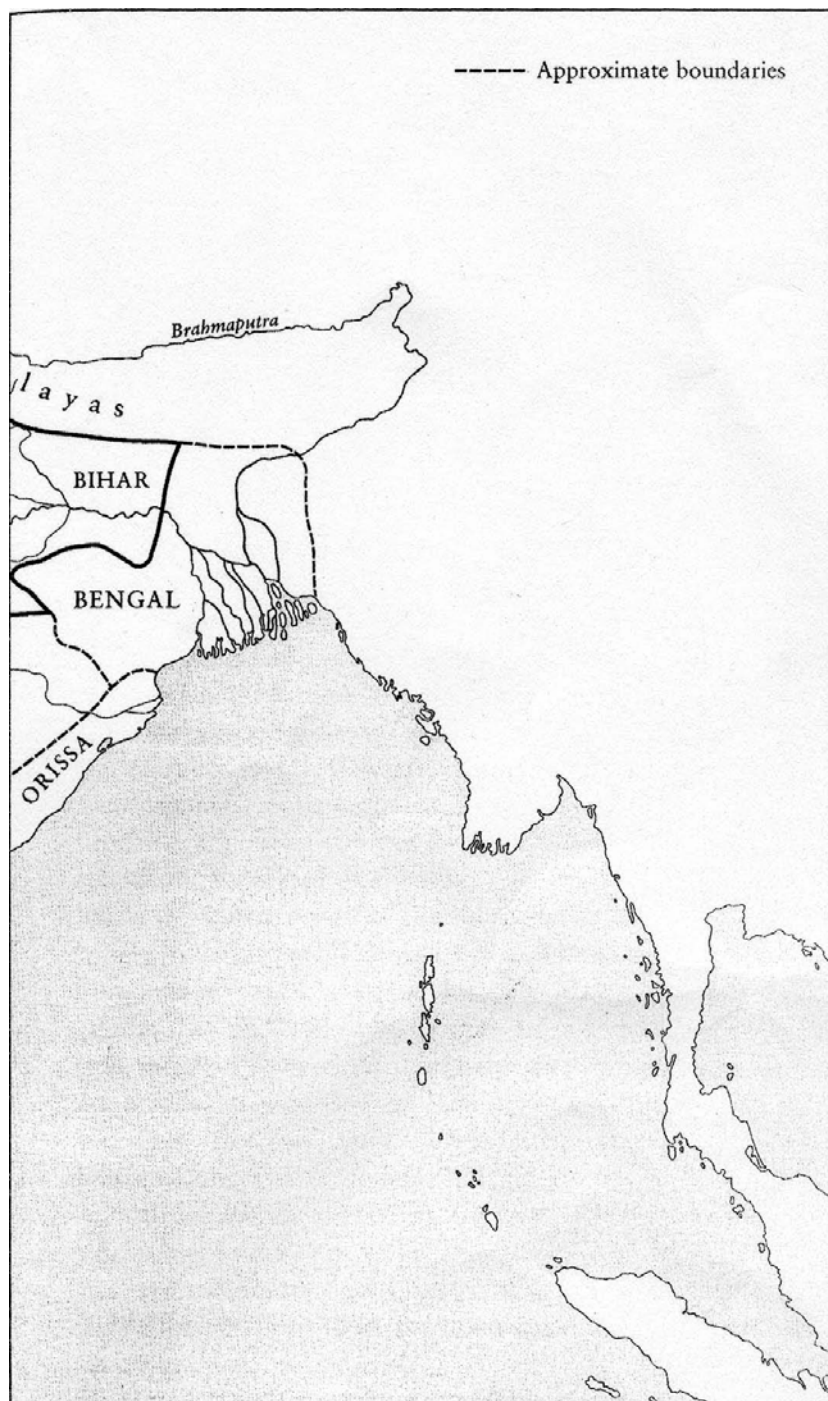
By the fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries, the Sultanate in the north had given way to a series of regional kingdoms, Gujarat, Malwa, Jaunpur, Delhi itself, and Bengal. In the Deccan and



Plate 1.2 Asoka Pillar, Ferozshah Kotla, Delhi.



Map 1 India c. 1500.



peninsular India, moreover, Sultanate incursions had overturned existing regimes, opening the way for new kingdoms to emerge. Shortly after Muhammad bin Tughluq, whose efforts to expand south were most intensive, withdrew from the capital he had established at Daulatabad in the Deccan, the Bahmanid kingdom, also dominated by Muslims, was established in 1345. After roughly a century and a half, it, like the Sultanate, gave way to more localized powers across the Deccan, and these kingdoms, Bijapur, Ahmadnagar, Berar, Bidar, and Golconda, persisted as Muslim dynasties from the late fifteenth century well into the Mughal era.

At about the same time as the establishment of the Bahmanids, the kingdom of Vijayanagar, based in Karnataka but soon expanding into Andhra and beyond, was founded by brothers who had served the Tughluqs, probably been Muslim for a time, and who now espoused a strong Shaivite tradition, that of worshipping Lord Shiva, as an ideology that sharply distinguished them from the Sultanate and Bahmanids. That kingdom emulated the military technology of the Sultanate, even employing units of north Indian mounted fighters. Although drawing on earlier models of south Indian kingship, Vijayanagar shared political idioms with the neighbouring states as well. Several kings, including the most powerful, Krishnadevaraya (r. 1509–29), called themselves the ‘sultan among Hindu kings’, with both the terms ‘sultan’ and ‘hindu’ (an Arab geographical term) taken from Muslims. Vijayanagar public buildings drew on the architectural forms of northern building; and even the dress of the king marked him as part of a wider political culture. Vijayanagar’s most persistent warfare was with Bijapur, a state whose capital city shared with its opponent the same name, ‘City of Victory’. By the fifteenth and sixteenth century, Hindu inscriptions further suggest a kind of equivalence among the dominant powers of the time, with the leaders of the Bahmanids (or Turks or Mughals) known as *asvapati*, the lords of the horses; Vijayanagar as *narapati*, the lord of men (infantry); and the Gajapatis (along the Orissan coast) as ‘lords of the elephants’.

Despite the emergence of political divisions and distinctive vernacular cultures, the first three centuries of Muslim rule fostered long-enduring changes in trading networks, social life, and religious institutions, as well as political strategies, that made for continuity

across a broad geographical area. The fifteenth and early sixteenth century in northern India foreshadowed in some ways the regional kingdoms that succeeded the Mughal Empire in the eighteenth century. Both were periods characterized by widespread similarities and connections, despite political divisions, as well as by creative cultural expression in local, vernacular contexts.

Bhakti leaders dating from this period whose teachings and cults persist to the present include Kabir (1440–1518), Guru Nanak (1469–1539), Mirabai (c. 1498–c. 1550), Dadu (1544–1603), Tukaram (1608–1649), and Chaitanya (1486–1533). Like the sufis, the bhakti teachers emphasized the individual's own devotion to the divine. A minor strand, represented by Kabir and Nanak, emphasized worship of a personal God without form. In so doing they distanced themselves from distinctive Hindu and Muslim symbols. As Nanak wrote, 'The gods and goddesses whom you worship and to whom you pray, what can they give? You wash them yourselves; left to themselves they will sink in the water.' Nanak by contrast encouraged a selfless love for God: 'He who is immersed in His love day and night sees Him immanent in the three worlds, and throughout all time. He becomes like Him whom he knows. He becomes wholly pure, his body is sanctified, and God dwells in his heart as his only love.'

More common than worshippers of a formless god were Vaishnavites devoted to Lord Vishnu; Shaivites, devoted to Lord Shiva; and worshippers of the Goddess (*devi*) in her many forms. Vaishnavite worship was focused on the manifestations of Lord Vishnu as either the ideal king, Lord Ram, or as the pastoral Lord Krishna, celebrated as child, cowherd, and lover. This emphasis on individual access to the divine, often coupled with critiques of merely formal ritual, nonetheless accommodated, for the most part, the guidance of Brahman priests, who played a central role in sectarian communities.

Both the Persian and the Indic traditions used erotic encounters to represent the relationship between the human and the divine. By the late fourteenth century, sufi poets were writing in a range of lyric and narrative forms, including the *masnawi* love stories that simultaneously depict a story of human passion and the quest for ultimate truth. These poets composed not only in Persian but also

in the vernaculars of north India, and, later, of the Deccan. They drew on the rich vocabulary and resonances of Indic philosophic and religious thought, as well as on a range of poetic conventions characteristic of bhakti poetry. Bhakti poets, in turn, were influenced by the new genres derived from Persian. Muslim chroniclers writing in the vernaculars, like early Arab historians before them, also enriched Islamic traditions by incorporating regional epic and legendary figures into their writings. In the Bengali *Nabi-vamsa* of the late sixteenth century, for example, the deities of the Hindu pantheon were simply understood as Islamic prophets.

In architecture as well the period was one of variety and creativity. To look only at mosques of the fifteenth century, for instance, no one would mistake the brick mosques of Bengal, the almost Gothic wooden structures of Kashmir, the temple-like pillared halls of Ahmedabad, or the massive, pylon-based mosques of Jaunpur for each other; yet all represented a Muslim culture new since the period had begun, now finding expression in a variety of local contexts. One measure of the centralizing Mughal power, which would soon emerge, is the extent to which it was able to achieve a common aesthetic taste, reflected in temples and mosques, palaces and forts, across its far-flung domains (as exemplified in plate 1.5).

THE MUGHAL EMPIRE

In 1526, the Delhi-based kingdom of the Afghan Muslim Lodi dynasty fell to the brilliant military strategy and superior artillery of Zahir al-Din Muhammad Babur (1483–1530) at Panipat, northwest of Delhi. Like the Sultans, the Mughals stimulated a new level of settled agriculture, military capability, and geographic integration. Babur was a scion of both Timur ('Tamerlane', 1336–1405) on his father's side and the Mongol Chingiz Khan (1167?–1227) on his mother's. It was the former lineage the dynasty cherished and it is, thus, an irony of history that since the nineteenth century these rulers have been called by a variant of the latter's name. Babur had longed for his lost patrimony in Samarkand and turned to Hindustan as what seemed poor compensation. Babur bears ready comparison, as the historian Stephen Dale has argued, to contemporary princes of the Renaissance in his self-cultivation and his eclectic interests,

from hard-boiled military strategy to the nuances of Turkic and Persian poetry. His own Turkic memoirs, and his daughter Gulbadan's Persian memoirs, are testimony to this image. Gulbadan recounted one of the most famous episodes of Babur's life – the emperor's willing sacrifice of his life to save his sick son:

When his Majesty came and saw how it was, his light-revealing countenance at once became sad and pitiful, and he began more and more to show sign of dread. His Majesty [said], 'Although I have other sons, I love none as I love Humayun. I crave that this cherished child may have his heart's desire and live long because he has not his equal in distinction.' During Humayun's illness his Majesty walked round him. He kept up that going-round, in anxiety and deep dejection. While going round he prayed, saying in effect: 'O God! If a life may be exchanged for a life, I who am Babur, I give my life and my being for Humayun.' That very day he fell ill, and Humayun poured water on his head, and came out and gave audience.

One exquisite later miniature illustrating Babur's memoirs depicts him laying out the kind of formal garden he so loved, at once an aspect of his range of skills and metaphor for the order he aspired to bring to individual and corporate life (plate 1.3). Gulbadan's memoirs, further, offer a rare view into the lives of the court women. In this account they are shown as counsellors and mediators among family members, they dispose of property, and they organize ritual occasions that define social solidarities. When Gulbadan died, the emperor Akbar helped carry her bier.

Babur ruled for a mere four years, and neither he, nor his son Humayun, forced into exile in Persia, did more than establish garrisons to mark the area they controlled. The foundation for an enhanced infrastructure of roads and the beginnings of agricultural surveys was laid by resurgent Afghans, the Surs, who ruled until Humayun, accompanied by Safavid immigrants, regained control of the kingdom in the final year of his life (1555–6). It was Humayun's son Akbar whose half-century of rule established the dynasty as an empire, brought about by conquests that moved the frontiers of Mughal control north to Kabul and Kashmir, east to Bengal and coastal Orissa, south to Gujarat and part of the Deccan and, most important of all, south-west from Delhi to Rajasthan.

Akbar embraced and then built on the Sultanate policy of a diverse and inclusive ruling elite. He sought to incorporate powerful

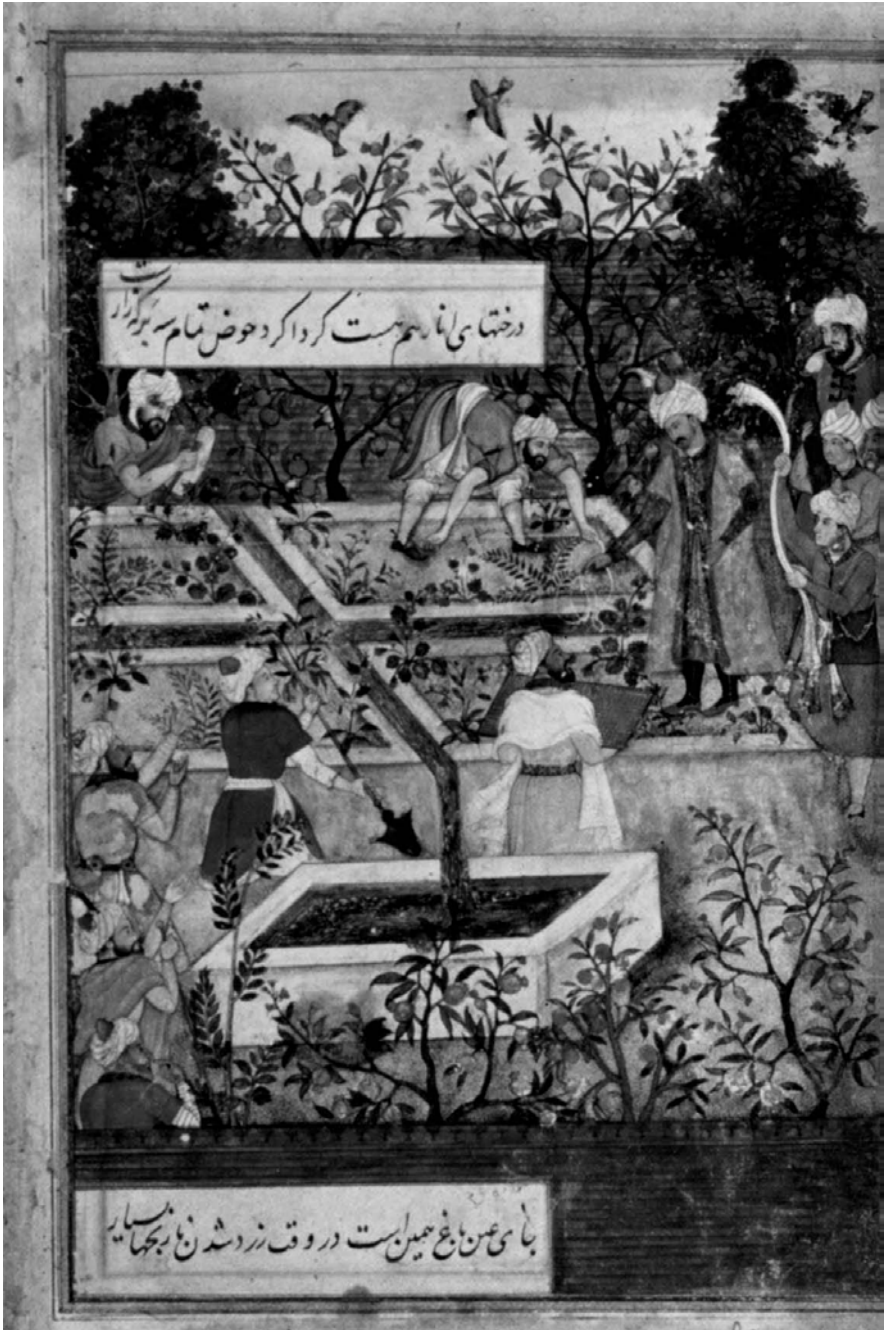


Plate 1.3 *Babur Supervising the Garden of Fidelity*, by Bishan Das, from the Baburnama.

indigenous lineages, above all those of the Rajputs, who were confirmed in rights to the revenue of their own domains. He began the dynastic custom of taking Rajput wives (who were not expected to convert to Islam), among them Jodh Bai, mother of Akbar's successor Jahangir (r. 1605–27). The diverse Mughal ruling elites comprised not only differing strands from central Asia, but Persians (who as Shi'a differed in religion from the majority Sunni Muslims), some Arabs, as well as locally born Muslims, Rajputs, together with a few Brahmans and, later, Marathas. The unifying ideology of the regime was that of loyalty, expressed through Persianate cultural forms, not a tribal affiliation (like that of the Ottomans), nor an Islamic or an Islamic sectarian identity (like that of the Safavids). This ideology also encompassed lower-level military and scribal officials, largely non-Muslim.

Loyalty was focused on the person of the ruler, the apex of a pyramid of vertical bonds. Akbar's chief memoirist and publicist, Abu'l Fazl, held up the emperor as a man of extraordinary vitality, universal curiosity, and master of every art. He fostered a new image of the emperor as not only a military and strategic leader, and patron of the holy and learned, but as himself a person of spiritual knowledge and charisma. In Abu'l Fazl's words in his celebrated *A'in-i-Akbari (Institutes of Akbar)*:

No dignity is higher in the eyes of God than royalty, and those who are wise drink from its auspicious fountain. A sufficient proof of this, for those who require one, is the fact that royalty is a remedy for the spirit of rebellion, and the reason why subjects obey. Royalty is a light emanating from God, and a ray from the sun, the illuminator of the universe, the argument of the book of perfection, the receptacle of all virtues. Many excellent qualities flow from the possession of this light: a paternal love toward the subjects; a large heart; a daily increasing trust in God; prayer and devotion. He must see that no injustice is done within his realm.

Akbar and his successors thus claimed a different kind of kingship from that of the Sultans.

The emperor's quasi-divine status was expressed not only in theoretical writings, but also in ceremony, sufi allegiance, artistic allegory, and architectural analogies. Akbar was associated with images of immanent light and human perfectibility cultivated among some Shi'i and sufi thinkers. His teachings, labelled the *din-i ilahi* or

‘divine faith’, served as a focus for a small number of court disciples who took the emperor not only as their royal but their spiritual master as well. Some few Hindus beyond the Rajput generals were among the inner circle of the elite in Akbar’s court. Among them were the architect of the empire’s agrarian policies, Todar Mal, and the courtier and confidant, Birbal, whose *bons mots* and humour have come down through history. There were court ‘ulama who opposed Akbar’s claims, no one more famously than the disaffected ‘Abdu’l-Qadir Badayuni (c. 1540–1615), thanks to whose indiscriminate ridicule Akbar was memorialized as an apostate.

Akbar’s use of Islamic symbols was not exclusionary, and he welcomed to his new court at Fatehpur Sikri for discussion Brahmans, yogis, Jains, Jesuit priests who travelled up from Portuguese trading enclaves on the south-west coasts, Zoroastrians, and Muslim scholars of every orientation. He, like Jahangir after him, was particularly fascinated by yogis, whose influence on Muslim thought and practice in India has been extensive (and little recognized). Like many intellectuals and holy men in the open climate of this period, Akbar sought shared esoteric or philosophic truths across traditions, as well as disciplinary practices in the pursuit of those truths. He patronized translations into Persian of the Sanskrit *Ramayana* (the story of Lord Ram) and *Mahabharata*, as well as miniature painting representing episodes of the two epics. He abolished the *jizya* taxes levied on non-Muslims.

Jahangir continued his father’s catholic religious interests. He was personally devoted not only to the Qadiri saint, Miyan Mir, but also to the Vaishnava yogi, Gosain Jadrup. He continued the practice of enrolling loyal nobles as disciples, who symbolized their allegiance by wearing his portrait and pearl earrings of servitude. Shah Jahan’s claims to legitimacy were made in stone. His architectural achievements include gardens, the planned city of Shahjahanabad (whose ‘Red Fort’ is represented in [plate 1.1](#)), and, most famed of all, the tomb dedicated to his cherished wife, the Taj Mahal ([plate 1.4](#)), all associated with paradisiacal symbols. By this symbolism, Shah Jahan made himself nothing less than the analogue of the divine, his paradise represented in greenery and stone. The Mughals shared such ritual elaborations with other early modern rulers across Eurasia, who in a variety of ways identified their aspirations to unparalleled

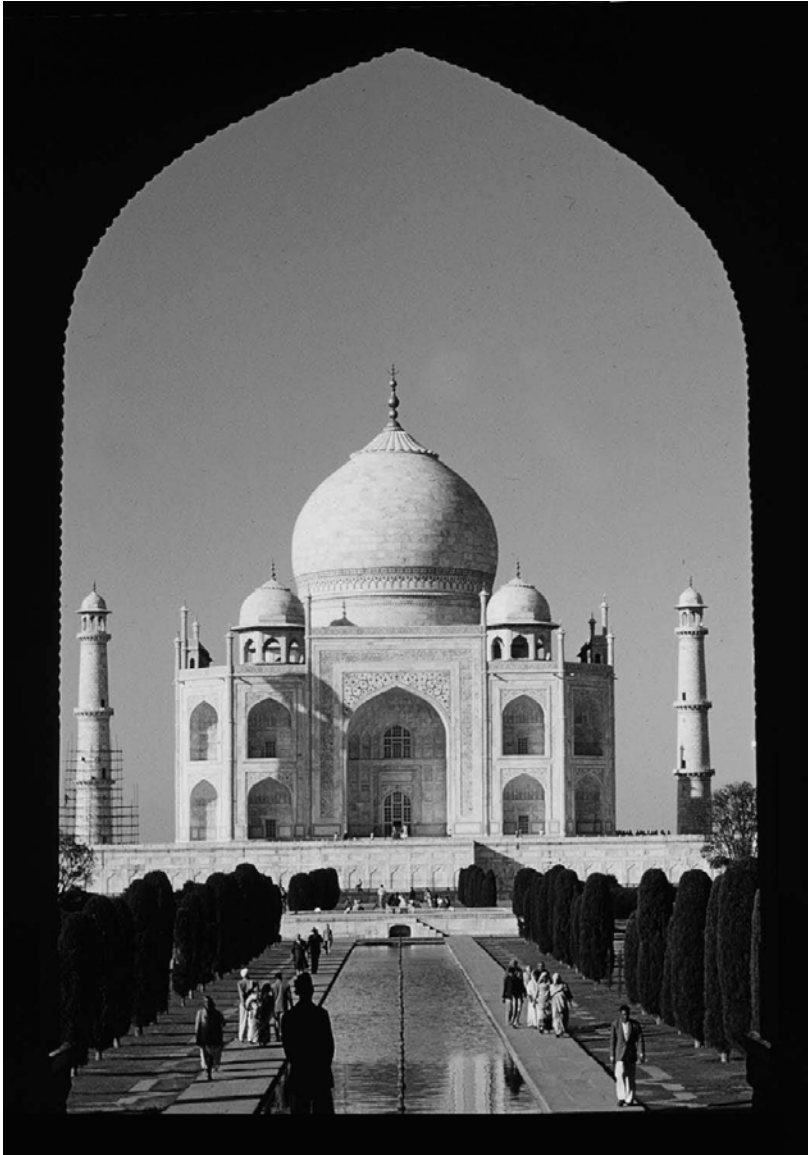


Plate 1.4 Taj Mahal, Agra, from the Great Gateway (1648).

power with expressions of cosmologically or divinely sanctioned rule.

A further key to Akbar's successes were the administrative reforms that created an enduring framework for rule. There was nothing specifically 'Islamic' about these strategies; they built on Sultanate

precedents, and in broad form were shared by early modern agrarian empires across Asia. Nobles were awarded ranks, known as *mansab*, demarcated decimally, and were expected to provide horsemen according to the rank number for the emperor's use. They were appointed to positions in two parallel hierarchies, one with civil responsibilities and one military – thus a check on each other – at levels from district, to province, to centre, throughout the empire. Nobles were assigned the right to collect the assessed tax revenue of pieces of land, *jagirs*, as the basis of their remuneration. By rotating these assignments frequently, nobles were incapacitated from building a local base that could challenge Mughal authority. Even a relatively centralized empire like this, however, was limited in its reach into local communities. Mughal officials typically negotiated for delivery of the revenue demand with lineage heads and chieftains, homogenized in Mughal usage as *zamindars* (land-holders).

At the bottom of this hierarchy were the peasant cultivators. Their condition under the Mughals has been a subject of controversy. In his classic study of the Mughal agrarian system, Irfan Habib concluded that the cultivating peasantry, though not owners of the land, hence unable to sell it, still possessed a hereditary right of occupancy so long as they paid the state's revenue demand. For Habib, the result was an unceasing oppression, as their superiors sought to strip the cultivators of all surplus. Growing in intensity as the seventeenth century proceeded, these exactions precipitated a series of revolts that shook the empire, and in the end helped bring about its downfall. Other historians have pointed out that the existence of extensive tracts of uncultivated land moderated exploitation, as cultivators could vote with their feet if the burden of taxation became intolerable. Further, as we discuss below, most agrarian revolts were zamindari-led, and so did not involve the peasantry as the main protagonists. Sustained by an expansive economy, the peasantry were, at the very least, unlikely to have emerged from the years of Mughal rule any worse off than they were at its start.

Generations of modern historians and politicians have blamed Shah Jahan's successor Aurangzeb for undoing the cultural pluralism and administrative efficiency of the empire. Aurangzeb had contended for the throne with his eldest brother, Dara Shukoh (1615–58); and the two have come down through history as ideological

opponents, Dara as the 'liberal' and Aurangzeb as the rigid 'conservative'. Dara was, indeed, an intellectual in the tradition of Akbar, who sought out shared philosophical truths in all religious traditions. He translated the Sanskrit *Upanishads* and wrote a treatise linking sufi and Upanishadic philosophical thought, his celebrated *Majma'u'l-bahrain* (The Mingling of the Two Oceans). To focus on divergent philosophies neglects the fact that Dara was a poor general and leader. It also ignores the fact that factional lines in the succession dispute were not, by and large, shaped by ideology, even though Aurangzeb, not surprisingly, accused his brother of idolatry. It is also worth noting that a major focus of Aurangzeb's reign was warfare directed against other Muslims. Although Aurangzeb encouraged a more narrow and austere Islamic style in courtly culture, that was not the cause of imperial decline.

Aurangzeb shifted but did not fundamentally alter the religious policy of the empire. However much the emperors fostered cultural pluralism, they all, like Aurangzeb, privileged the Islamic. Aurangzeb generously patronized the 'ulama and ordered a compilation of judicial opinions in the *Fatawa-yi 'Alamgiri*. He cultivated an image of himself as a man of personal piety. He patronized Islamic leaders and sites; he restored policies that applied differential taxes on Hindus (not incidentally a source of revenue for his hard-pressed regime); and he favoured Muslims for official employment. Aurangzeb's towering mosque in Benares was an assertion of Mughal power and Islamic strength. But his destruction of temples in Benares, Mathura, and Rajasthan had less to do with iconoclasm, since he continued to patronize other Hindu temples, than with the presumed disloyalty of nobles associated with these sites. The building and patronage of the temples of loyal nobles, like the erection of mosques that enjoyed state support, was regarded as an element in state policy. Temples, like other buildings constructed in the shared imperial architectural style, among them the Rajput-built Hindu temple in [plate 1.5](#), were visible manifestations of Mughal power. Similarly, Aurangzeb's accusation of the Sikh guru Tegh Bahadur (r. 1664–75) of blasphemy, and his subsequent execution, must be seen in the context of imperial politics. Tegh Bahadur was an active military organizer and proselytizer with family ties to a supporter of Dara; his execution mingled Islamic

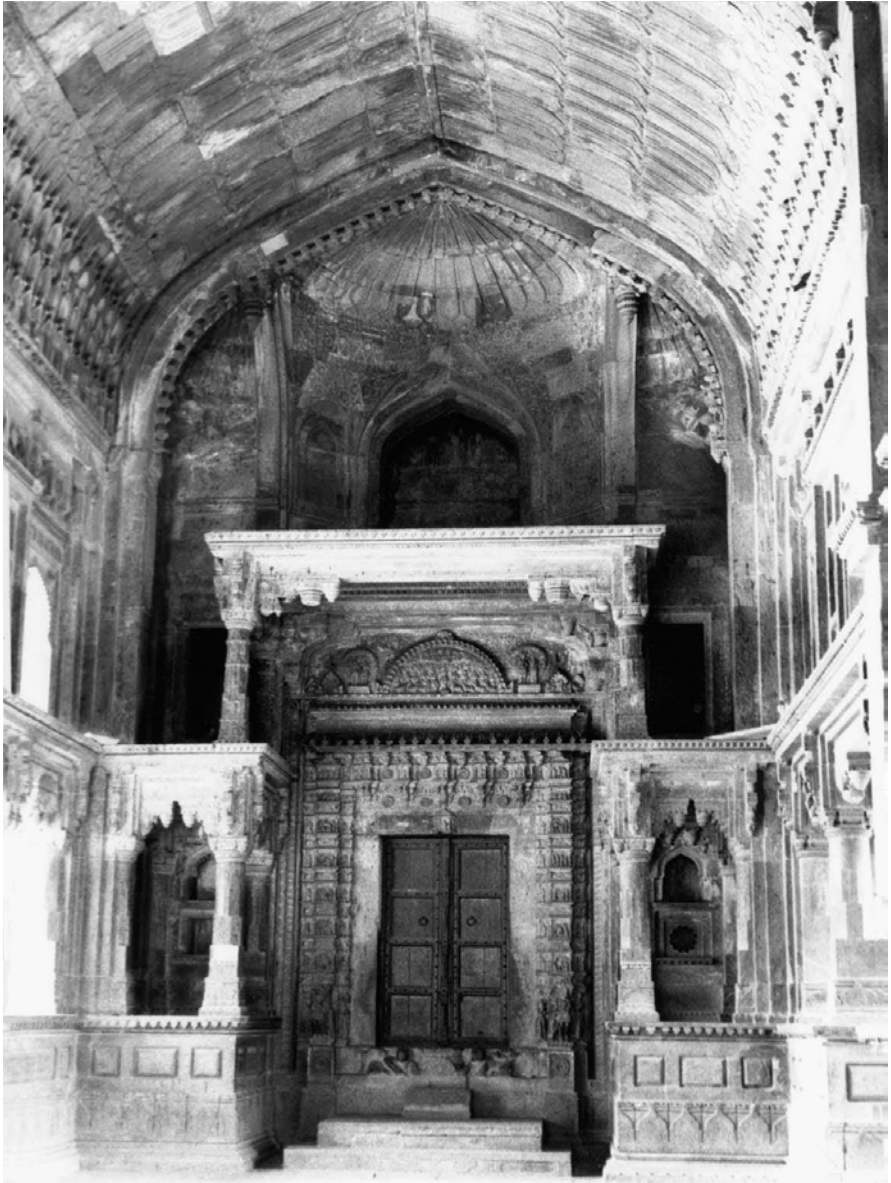


Plate 1.5 Interior of Hindu Temple constructed in the Mughal Style, by Raja Man Singh, at Brindaban.

justifications with imperial politics, as had Jahangir's execution of the fifth guru, on similar grounds, before him. To the end, Aurangzeb depended on non-Muslim courtiers. More than a quarter of the mansab holders along with his leading general were Hindus.

Did Aurangzeb's very success in achieving the widest expansion of the empire, as is often argued, sow the seeds of its undoing? He was determined to expand into the Deccan at any cost against the Muslim kingdoms that had succeeded the Bahmani Sultanate and against the newly insurgent Marathas, a formidable enemy with their guerilla tactics and strategically placed hill forts. In 1685 his forces took Bijapur; in 1689, Golconda. The core area of the north was neglected as the emperor, his court, and his armies, a veritable moving city as the French physician Bernier's memoirs vividly evoke, remained far from Delhi. The system of co-opting new elites through the award of jagirs ran aground as the pace of need, exacerbated by the debilitating costs of these campaigns, outran the availability of profitable grants. Not only the Marathas, but also Sikh and Jat zamindars, as well as some among the Rajputs, soon challenged imperial rule. These insurgents were, however, kept in check until the end of Aurangzeb's reign.

Clearly, a focus on the personality, or even the policies, of one emperor, whatever short-term problems he may have created, is inadequate in explaining imperial decline. Such a focus fits too easily with the old European theory of Asiatic 'despotism'. Two more persuasive lines of argument suggest long-term transitions, incipient in the seventeenth century, that contributed to accelerating decentralization after Aurangzeb's death in 1707. One, perhaps surprisingly, is that the upstart warriors, Marathas, Jats, and the like, as coherent social groups with military and governing ideals, were themselves a product of the Mughal context, which recognized them and provided them with military and governing experience. Their successes were a product of Mughal success. A second line of argument is economic. Throughout Asia, the economies of the agrarian empires had been fuelled in the seventeenth century by the influx of specie gained from New World conquest, as Europeans sought valued commodities. Asian economies, including that of the Mughals, were increasingly monetized, and cash-crop production, demand-responsive, expanded. Evidence of the vast extent and

wealth of the empire remain in the dynasty's monuments, above all those of Shah Jahan. Indian seaborne trade, to be sure, was largely in the hands of Arabs and, from the beginning of the sixteenth century, the Portuguese. English and Dutch trading companies further established themselves in coastal enclaves during the seventeenth century. But the monetization and expanding commerce generated by this trade gave rise, as we shall see in the next chapter, to new Indian commercial and political elites, especially in the southern and eastern coastal areas. The regional states of the eighteenth century can thus be seen as the fruition, not the end, of Mughal rule.

The challenges to Aurangzeb did not come from groups that had been suppressed under Muslim rule and now sought to regain their autonomy. Marathas, Sikhs, Jats, and even Rajputs represented social groups with old names but new cohesion and status. These were not age-old Indian 'castes'. One of the surprising arguments of fresh scholarship, based on inscriptional and other contemporaneous evidence, is that until relatively recent centuries, social organization in much of the subcontinent was little touched by the four normative hierarchic categories (*varnas*) known from Sanskrit Vedic texts: Brahman priests as ritual guardians of social purity; Kshatriya warriors; Vaisya merchants; and Shudra peasants. Nor were 'sub-castes' or *jati* (endogamous groups identified by *varna*) the building blocks of society. There was, in practice, far more importance given to occupational identities and individual mobility than most commentators since the colonial period have recognized. A major stimulus to the use of the Sanskrit categories appears to have been the claims of aspiring dynasts in the Mughal period who, as parvenu *kshatriya*, in turn identified peasants and soldiery as ranked groups, giving new meanings to old titles that earlier had had only loose regional or occupational meaning. When these terms are adduced, they not only may allow a claim on improved social standing, but also may contribute to social integration across cultural and linguistic regions. Muslim social hierarchy as well, one might note, also took on new formality, evident by the eighteenth century, with the well-born identifying themselves in terms of four ranked putative descent groups: Sayyid, descendants of the Prophet; Shaikh, descendants of his Companions; Mughal; and Pathan. The category of 'shaikh' was particularly porous in absorbing the upwardly mobile.

What Susan Bayly calls ‘paradigmatic case’ of kingly social mobility is that of Shivaji Bhonsle (1630–80), the pivotal figure in the Maratha insurgency that so plagued Aurangzeb in the Deccan. Shivaji was of cultivator background, from peoples known in western India as Marathas. By the sixteenth century, the term ‘Maratha’ had acquired greater respectability through its use by the Deccani sultans as they rewarded these communities for their service as soldiers and office holders. Shivaji’s father served the states of Bijapur and Ahmadnagar, as a senior commander, before unsuccessfully leading his own force against the Mughals. Shivaji himself continued as a rebel fighter. On one famous occasion he pretended to surrender, only to murder the Bijapuri general, Afzal Khan, with a concealed ‘tiger claw’ as he feigned an embrace. Subsequently, he was roundly defeated by Aurangzeb’s Rajput general, Jai Singh, and accepted a mansab in Mughal service, only to defy imperial ritual when he felt slighted by the rank awarded him. Shivaji gained legitimacy from Mughal honours, but he also sought status elsewhere. Under the Mughals, the term *Rajput* had become the symbol of legitimate kshatriya rule, and so Shivaji determined to acquire that status for himself. He recruited a learned Brahman to his service, as Rajputs typically did. Together with other Brahmans, he provided Shivaji with the ritual genealogical services that legitimized him as a descendant of warrior forebears. In 1674, Shivaji had himself installed as king in elaborate Brahmanic ceremonies. Shivaji exemplifies the role of the successful warrior in fostering formalized caste ideals. He welcomed men of skill and loyalty with no regard to birth, but he subsequently built classifications of jati and varna into his courtly ritual and organization.

The Mughal period was thus one of far-reaching political, economic, and social reconfigurations. Cultural life flourished as well in the context of internal pluralism and regional cross-fertilization. Mughal miniature painting and architecture, both with Persian roots but utterly transformed in the Indian environment, endure as the most visible legacies of that brilliant cultural life. Medical systems, the Sanskrit *ayurveda* and the Arabic *yunani tibb* (derived from Greek theories), which share a holistic framework of temperature and moisture, interacted to their mutual enrichment. Music flourished. Fundamental elements in Vaishnavite devotionism in

particular took shape, as the work of poets like Sur during Akbar's reign, and the beloved *Ramcaritmanas* of Tulsidas make clear. The most luminous Islamic thinker of this period, the Naqshbandi sufi Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi (1564–1624), serves as a reminder that the subcontinent itself has been a centre of Islamic thought and practice. Sirhindi, who criticized imperial cultural policies, was a thorn in the side of the empire, and was even imprisoned for his self-aggrandizement by Jahangir. But his cosmological and philosophical thought had lasting impact not only within the subcontinent but in central Asia and the Ottoman lands as well. The basic openness and eclecticism of the period is illustrated by the incorporation, with the advent of the European trading companies, of new techniques of shipbuilding, horticulture, and even art (for example, in depictions of landscape and perspective). A metaphor of 'stagnation' could not be more misleading.

The flexibility and openness of Mughal institutions is also underlined if that period is described not, as it long has been, as part of 'Medieval' India or 'Moslem' India, terms that suggest isolation and exoticism, but instead, to use the term now preferred by many historians, as 'Early Modern'. Such a description points to a range of transformations that began about 1500 across Eurasia, and not only in Europe where the periodization 'Early Modern' for the sixteenth to eighteenth centuries is standard usage. The historian of Mughal India, John Richards, has identified several of these unprecedented worldwide processes of change, starting with the creation of global sea passages that linked the entire world for the first time. The impact of these changes on India, as pointed out above, includes intensification of monetization and the expansion of textile production evident already by the seventeenth century. This era also saw population growth and the spread of the agricultural frontier in India as in many other world areas. India, like other areas of Asia, adopted New World cultivars, among them tobacco, maize, and peppers. The Early Modern period was also an era of newly centralized states, of which the Mughal was one. And it was a period of technological diffusion, not least in relation to gunpowder. This technology was so important that one historian, Marshall Hodgson, described the great agrarian empires of the period – Ottoman, Safavid, Mughal, Ching – as 'gunpowder empires', not only because of the power

available to those able to deploy improved personal firearms and cannon, but because these regimes were stimulated to new levels of bureaucratic control in order to support new military technology.

What then, to ask again, about 'Muslimness'? For roughly half a millennium Muslim dynasties dominated political life in the sub-continent. Both 'Orientalist' views and recent Hindu nationalism have argued that Hindu beliefs and institutions were repressed in these long centuries. In contrast, to reiterate points made above, the very institutions of social organization, as well as new patterns of Vaishnavite and Shaivite worship, emerged precisely in this period. Islamic thought and practice, above all within the framework of sufi devotionism, were similarly transformed. The regimes were 'Muslim' in that they were led by Muslims, patronized (among others) learned and holy Muslim leaders, and justified their existence in Islamic terms. But loyalty, not religious affiliation, defined participation, and non-Muslim elites were central to the functioning of Sultanate and Mughal regimes. There were no programmes of mass, much less forced, conversion.

Were the regimes then 'foreign', as is frequently alleged? Certainly, the dynasties were founded by people from outside the current political boundaries of South Asia, and immigrants saw India as 'a land of opportunity'. But cultural areas spilled out beyond current borders, and those within central Asian circuits, or ocean-borne trading networks east and west, arguably had more in common within these areas than with putatively 'national' groupings. What does 'foreign' mean in an era before modern states and passports? How long does it take for those of different origin to be accepted as 'natural' in any given place, especially when indigenous symbolic systems and institutions are, one could argue, themselves changing in interaction with those of the sometime outsiders? The fact that Hindus and Muslims came to see themselves as distinct religious communities, even two nations, is a central fact in the modern history of India. But it is crucial to understand, despite continuities in terminology, how very different religious groupings of the past were from those of today. Pre-modern political regimes fostered upper-class identities that incorporated individuals of diverse regions and religions. The illustrations in this chapter each represent a specific noble (Firoz Shah, Babur, Shah Jahan, Raja Man Singh) to whom a range of

allies and subordinates owed allegiance. Each artifact made visible this noble's claim to assert military might, to impose order on the society he controlled, and to act as the apex of subordinates from whom he took service and resources. The contrasting image of self-conscious 'horizontal' communities of Hindus and Muslims, like the image of pre-colonial India as a land of self-sufficient villages, rigid caste hierarchies, and overall stagnation, reads characteristics of colonial society into the pre-colonial past.

2

Mughal twilight: The emergence of regional states and the East India Company

Our time traveller in 1707, especially if he had been misled by European accounts of ‘Oriental despots’, may well have failed to appreciate the extent to which the Mughal Empire, like other pre-modern political systems of that scale, operated by a hierarchic distribution of authority among different levels of society. There was no monopoly of military force; there was no monopoly of political authority. The Mughal himself was *shahinshah*, ‘king of kings’, hence one sovereign among many. Competition to expand geographically was always endemic, as was competition between the vertical levels of the system. It is conflict, as Bernard Cohn has written using the late Mughal period as an example of such systems, that achieves the precarious consensus and balance that allows such political systems to persist. Effective rule required not only resolving competition but also judgment about the conflicts with which to engage. During the first half of the eighteenth century Mughal power contracted, while those who had once been subordinate to the Mughals flourished. Among the new regional powers was a joint stock company of English traders, which, by century’s end, was poised to claim the mantle of the Mughals as ruler of the subcontinent.

THE ‘FAULT LINES’ OF MUGHAL CONTROL

A cogent perspective on Aurangzeb as ruler comes from one Bhimsen, a Hindu Kayastha memoirist, who, in his final decades of service, acted as auditor and inspector for a Rajput noble. Writing at